



Wandering albatross

Diomedea exulans

stands upright on large webbed feet



With a wingspan of up to 12 ft (3.5 m), the wandering albatross is the largest flying bird in the world. Old males become so white they have been called “snowy albatrosses,” but the bird’s scientific name comes from the Latin term for “living as an exile.” This refers to the fact that wandering albatrosses spend months at a time on the wing in the world’s southern oceans.

Male wandering albatrosses are 20 percent heavier than females, but with only slightly larger wings. They forage farther south than females and their 12 percent greater wing loading (body weight related to wing area) seems to help them deal with stronger winds. Immature birds circle the southern hemisphere before becoming old enough to breed at 10 years. Wandering albatrosses form large breeding colonies on remote islands, creating nest mounds out of mud and

vegetation. Pairs mate for life, then breed every two years, incubating one egg for around 80 days and sharing parental duties.

Longline fishing threat

Albatrosses have a very good sense of smell thanks to their large, tubular external nostrils, and most of their diet is fish and squid taken at the ocean’s surface or in shallow dives. Scavenging around fishing boats for fish and other unwanted sea creatures that are thrown aside gives these seabirds an easy feeding option, but has increased risk. With just 8,000 pairs nesting in any year and a slow reproductive rate, wandering albatrosses, in particular, are extremely vulnerable to threats such as drowning when caught on baited hooks from long-line trawlers.

↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)

⚖ 18–25 lb (8–11.5 kg)

⊗ Vulnerable

🐙 Squid, fish, offal

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Subantarctic oceans